

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Flooding

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Move to higher ground if water is rising or a flash-flood warning affects you. Never walk, swim, or drive through floodwater; depth, current, contamination, and road damage are hard to judge. Follow evacuation orders and avoid basements or low areas that can fill rapidly.

Do now.

- ☐ **Get above the water**
01 Leave low ground and move to a safe higher location. If a road is flooded, turn around and choose another route.
- ☐ **Read the local notice**
02 Check alerts, road closures, and evacuation instructions. Do not rely on the road being open because it was open earlier.
- ☐ **Keep away from hazards**
03 Floodwater may hide energized wires, debris, sewage, chemicals, and missing road surface. Keep children and pets away.
- ☐ **If trapped, call for help**
04 Give your precise location to emergency services. Move to a higher level if possible; avoid entering a closed attic where you could become trapped by rising water.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Identify higher ground reachable without crossing water. Pack essentials while routes remain dry; if they are already cut off, use the safest elevated space available and signal for help. Stay out of a basement that is taking on water.

Watch for.

Flooding can begin far from the heaviest rain. Do not attempt to cross flowing water to reach a vehicle, home, or belongings.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: get above the water. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Flooding can begin far from the heaviest rain. Do not attempt to cross flowing water to reach a vehicle, home, or belongings.

Keep essentials within reach.

For flooding, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Identify higher ground reachable without crossing water. Pack essentials while routes remain dry; if they are already cut off, use the safest elevated space available and signal for help. Stay out of a basement that is taking on water. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Return only when officials say it is safe. Photograph damage without entering unstable structures, use protective gear for cleanup, and check the water supply for advisories.

First decision: Get above the water

Leave low ground and move to a safe higher location. If a road is flooded, turn around and choose another route. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Identify higher ground reachable without crossing water. Pack essentials while routes remain dry; if they are already cut off, use the safest elevated space available and signal for help. Stay out of a basement that is taking on water. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Flooding can begin far from the heaviest rain. Do not attempt to cross flowing water to reach a vehicle, home, or belongings. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Move to higher ground if water is rising or a flash-flood warning affects you. Never walk, swim, or drive through floodwater; depth, current, contamination, and road damage are hard to judge. Follow evacuation orders and avoid basements or low areas that can fill rapidly. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For flooding, keep the specific hazard in view: Flooding can begin far from the heaviest rain. Do not attempt to cross flowing water to reach a vehicle, home, or belongings.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: If trapped, call for help. Give your precise location to emergency services. Move to a higher level if possible; avoid entering a closed attic where you could become trapped by rising water. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov · Floods](#)

<https://www.ready.gov/floods>

[CDC · Floodwater safety](#)

<https://www.cdc.gov/floods/about/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/flooding/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.